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### Film-Induced Tourism as a Vehicle For Destination Marketing: Is it Worth the Efforts?

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# FILM-INDUCED TOURISM AS A VEHICLE FOR DESTINATION MARKETING: IS IT WORTH THE EFFORTS?

Jeeyeon (Jeannie) Hahm  
Youcheng Wang

**ABSTRACT.** This study examined the impact of a film on the featured destination's image and travel intentions through comparing the results of a one-group pretest-posttest quasi-experiment. Then, the effect of destination attributes and overall image on travel intentions is examined simultaneously through path analysis. The results indicate that the role of the overall image as a mediating variable is not significant as respondents relied more on specific destination image attributes on their intention to visit. This was even more prominent after the viewing of the film. The overall image had the strongest direct effect on visit interest in future for both pretest and posttest.

**KEYWORDS.** Film-induced tourism, destination image, image attributes, overall image, travel intentions, path analysis

## INTRODUCTION

Films have the potential to create both positive and negative impacts on tourism of a destination (Busby & Klug, 2001; Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). On one hand, films may generate enormous benefits to the local economy, preservation of sites, destination image, multiplier effect, property values, visitor influx, and infrastructure (e.g., Croy & Walker, 2003; Riley, Baker, & Van Doren, 1998). On the other hand, the environment, infrastructure, traffic, property values, heritage, host community, visitor experience, economy, culture, and privacy could be threatened as a result of the exposure of the destination in a film (e.g., Busby & Klug, 2001). This

type of tourism is called film-induced tourism. According to Beeton (2005), film-induced tourism refers to visitation to sites where movies and TV programs have been filmed as well as tours to production studios, including film-related theme parks. While academic research on film-induced tourism has been around since the early 1990s, the popularity and extensiveness of such research have increased only in recent years. Particularly, the impact of films on the image of a destination and travel intentions has been supported by academic studies (e.g., Croy, 2010; Kim & Richardson, 2003; Shani, Wang, Hudson, & Gil, 2009; Tasci, 2009). For example, a survey conducted in the United Kingdom revealed that 8 out of 10

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British people get their holiday travel destination ideas from films and 1 in 5 will actually travel to the location depicted in their favorite film (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy raised awareness of, increased motivation or likelihood to visit New Zealand for potential visitors as 65% expressed that they were more likely to visit the country because of the films or associated publicity (Croy, 2010).

The influence of film on creating awareness of and familiarity of a destination that could possibly lead to visitation has increasingly been recognized by destination management organizations (DMOs; Croy, 2010). The Oahu Visitors Bureau, a resort, and an airline partnered with Columbia Pictures in an effort to promote *50 First Dates* (2004), a romantic comedy that was filmed on the island of Oahu, Hawaii. The promotional campaign included an electronic marketing campaign that focused on driving visitors to the film's mini-website that featured a chance to win a trip to Oahu (Movie Highlights, 2004). Foreseeing the impact of the *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy, Tourism New Zealand—the organization responsible for marketing New Zealand to the world—implemented an image management process even before the production of the film began which successfully continued during production and after the release of the films.

It has become apparently important to measure the impact caused by the viewing of a movie; however, measuring and quantifying the actual impact or actual tourist visits caused by the movie proves to be a challenge (Mestre, del Ray, & Stanishovski, 2008). Many studies have used the increase of visitor numbers to film locations (Beeton, 2004; Busby, Brunt, & Lund, 2003; Croy & Walker, 2003; Riley et al., 1998; Riley & Van Doren, 1992; Schofield, 1996; Tooke & Baker, 1996). Other studies examined positive and negative effects of film on tourism (Beeton, 2005, 2006, 2008; Mestre et al., 2008; Mordue, 1999, 2001).

The growing research on film-induced tourism also include: (a) the influence of film on the decision to travel (Busby & Klug, 2001; Cohen, 1986; Riley et al., 1998; Riley & Van Doren, 1992; Tooke & Baker, 1996; Urry, 1990); (b) film tourists themselves (Macionis & Beverly, 2009); (c) destination marketing

activities related to film-induced tourism (Cohen, 1986; Grihault, 2003; Hudson & Ritchie, 2006); and (d) film-induced tourism from perspectives of planning and development (Buchmann, 2010; Croy, 2010; Heitmann, 2010; Karpovich, 2010; Kim, 2010; Portegies, 2010). Most of the previous studies on the impact of film on destination image and travel intentions have been based on assumptions or anecdotal evidence. This empirical study examines the causal relationships among destination image attributes, overall image, and travel intentions at the same time using real data. To date, there is no study that examines the relationships of these variables simultaneously in the context of film-induced tourism. This study contributes to the literature on film-induced tourism and associated tourist behavior. The objectives of this study are: (a) to assess the impact of a specific film on the featured destination's image, and (b) to examine the effect of the destination image attributes and overall destination image on travel behavioral intentions.

### **FILM-INDUCED TOURISM ON DESTINATION IMAGE AND DECISION TO TRAVEL**

Destination image is one of the most prevalent research topics in the existing tourism literature. There is a wide range of destination image studies available for over three decades, in which different approaches have been proposed and applied. Although the concept of destination image has not been comprehended cohesively (Kim & Richardson, 2003), studies agree that image is a fundamental factor in the decision making (positive or negative) of the destination selection process of travelers (Gartner, 1993; Goodrich, 1978; Gunn, 1988; Lew, 1988; O'Leary & Deegan, 2003; Um & Crompton, 1990; Woodside & Lysons, 1989). The initial image formation stage before the trip is the most important phase in the destination selection process (Gunn, 1988; Mercer, 1971). According to Gartner (1993), destination images are developed by three hierarchically interrelated components: cognitive, affective,

and conative. The conative image is analogous to behavior since it is the intent or action component. Conation may be considered as the likelihood of visiting a destination within a certain time period (Pike & Ryan, 2004). The creation of a destination image stimulates information search behavior concerning that destination and this heightened interest level leads to potential travel behavior to visit the location.

Many researchers have clearly illustrated that perceptions of destinations and purchase decisions are positively correlated (Mayo & Jarvis, 1981), confirming that the image of an area is a critical selection factor (Woodside & Lysonski, 1989). Therefore, tourist decisions could be realistically predicted depending on the type of image they have of a particular destination (Echtner & Ritchie, 1993; Goodrich, 1978; Hunt, 1975). Destination marketers use visual promotional tools—such as advertising, travel brochures, and travel guidebooks—in an effort to portray a desirable image to influence potential tourists (Tasci, 2009). Of the visual promotional tools, advertising has been prominently researched as a medium to improve destination image and to attract tourists (Ahmed, 1996; Bojanic, 1991; MacKay & Fesenmaier, 1997). A positive relationship between being exposed to an advertisement and favorable attitudes toward and likelihood of visiting the destination has been found (Bojanic, 1991). Unlike the destination-originated information sources, there are information sources that are not produced with the intention to depict an attractive image to lure tourists. However, these sources—television, film, magazines, books, and the Internet—could play an important role in forming a destination image and influencing the tourist decision to travel (Beerli & Martín, 2004; Govers, Go, & Kumar, 2007; Iwashita, 2003; Kim & Richardson, 2003). In particular, non-tourist directed visual media, such as films and television, tend to create higher credibility and market penetration in a short period of time (Butler, 1990; Crompton, 1979; Gartner, 1993), which is a powerful impact that destination marketers cannot afford to do with the traditional tourist directed methods. Due to expanding accessibility and high credibility, films and television will become even more

important in shaping images of a destination and influencing visitation to it (Brown & Singhal, 1993; Butler, 1990).

Many destinations use a film as an aid in promoting and creating a positive image of their destination recognizing the huge impact it has on attracting potential visitors. The aforementioned Tourism New Zealand is a good example of this management strategy at the national-level. In the United States, many DMOs at the city- or county-level market their destination with the help of a popular film or support film production on their official websites. Visit Savannah—Savannah's Convention and Visitors Bureau (CVB)—provides a list of movie tours on their official website. Film locations for *Midnight in the Garden of Good and Evil* and *Forrest Gump* are highlighted on the website (<http://savannahvisit.com>). The Greater Miami CVB has a direct link titled "Filming in Miami" under the "visitors" section that takes the visitor to FilMiami that represents the three Greater Miami Film Offices. The website for FilMiami (<http://www.filmiami.org>) is a one stop shop for all production needs from various production resources and locations to permit information. This shows the support for film production in the area of Greater Miami, Florida (<http://www.miamiandbeaches.com>). The CVB of Austin, Texas shows their support for film production in the area by having "Film Commission" as one of the major tabs on the main page of the website. The "Film" page highlights the fact that Austin is "America's No. 1 Filmmaking Destination." The site has everything a film production needs, such as regulations and permits, studios, film directory, and even film incentives to make the filming process in Austin more affordable and easier (<http://www.austintexas.org>).

Academic researchers have studied the relationship between film-induced images and visitation to filmed locations (Riley et al., 1998; Tooke & Baker, 1996). Tooke and Baker (1996) showed that film influences an increase in visitor numbers at the filmed location in their investigation of the impact of television films on the popularity of filmed locations, manifested by visitor numbers. Riley et al. (1998) found that

films increased visitation to the filmed locations for at least 4 years after their releases.

It has been found that a favorable image positively influences the pre-travel and post-travel behaviors (i.e., intention to visit, revisit, enjoyment, and satisfaction) whereas a negative image has the opposite effect (Phillips & Jang, 2007; Tasci, 2009). However, Shani et al. (2009) found no dramatic change from positive to negative perception of South America after viewing a film with controversial content. Yet, the results showed an increase in the desire to visit South America and in the likelihood to plan a vacation there. It has been suggested that especially in the case of distant and not well-known destinations, even negative exposure could be beneficial to the image of the destination (Croy & Walker, 2003). Tasci (2009) showed that visual information can improve the image of a destination's attractions, increase its desirability, increase the intention to visit, and bridge social distances between people. Kim and Richardson (2003) provided some empirical evidence that a popular film could significantly affect some of the destination image components and interest in visiting the place. Morgan, Pritchard, and Piggott (2003) suggested that *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy generated a basis for promotional campaigns and a worldwide interest for New Zealand. Hudson and Ritchie (2006) presented a conceptual framework for understanding film-induced tourism. According to the model, a film-induced tourist is interested in visiting a destination through push or pull factors of motives, which are enthused by one or more of three factors: (a) destination marketing activities; (b) film-specific factors; and (c) the destination attributes. In addition, there is a feedback loop in the model that indicates that impacts—positive and negative—will have an effect on the destination attributes. The study by Busby and Klug (2001) also found that most of their study respondents would consider traveling to film locations in the future. In addition, the authors documented that there are different forms of film-induced tourism and each tourist is motivated by various factors when visiting filmed locations.

According to Riley and Van Doren (1992), tourists are lured to film locations not only for

the picturesque physical environments but also for reasons of pilgrimage, nostalgia, and escape. Riley et al. (1998) agree that a destination should have distinct type of qualities in order to attract people. The ideal formula to entice people to a film location includes amazing landscape qualities, a unique social and cultural outlook, an icon, and/or an image that tourists can relate to and wish to explore (Riley & Van Doren, 1992). Building on their previous work, Riley et al. added that storyline themes, exciting sequences, and human relationships attract visitors to a destination. It has been found that film is a successful medium for tourism if the storyline and site are closely interrelated and if the film involves the audience in the story giving them emotional experience that they link with the destination (Tooke & Baker, 1996).

## METHODOLOGY

### Survey Instrument

This study used self-administered pretest and posttest questionnaires. The questionnaires consisted of both structured (scale format) and unstructured (open-ended) measurements after an extensive review of previous literature on destination image measurement (e.g., Baloglu & Mangaloglu, 2001; Chen & Kerstetter, 1999; Dann, 1996; Driscoll, Lawson, & Niven, 1994; Echtner & Ritchie, 1991, 1993; Fridgen, 1987; Hsu, Wolfe, & Kang, 2004; MacKay & McVetty, 2002; Milman & Pizam, 1995; Murphy, 1999; Reilly, 1990; Tapachai & Waryszak, 2000; Walmsley & Jenkins, 1993; Woodside & Lysonski, 1989). Researchers have recognized the importance of using both methods (Pike, 2002) in that a combination of structured and unstructured measurements should be utilized to capture the complex concept of destination image (Echtner & Ritchie, 1993). The purpose of the scale items was to focus on the common, attribute-based components of destination image (Echtner & Ritchie, 1993). The final list consisted of 16 destination image attributes that were measured on a 5-point Likert scale. Open-ended questions were included in the pretest and posttest questionnaires in order

to capture the unique and distinctive images that could not have been identified by the scale items. The open-ended question on both pretest and posttest questionnaires required respondents to write down images or characteristics in the form of adjectives or nouns that came to mind when they thought of the destination. There was no limit to the number of words that were expected from the respondents. There was another set of open-ended questions on the posttest questionnaire that focused on uncovering the aspects of the movie that created a positive or negative image of the destination.

### **The Film**

A destination-specific film was used as the treatment between the pretest-posttest stages. The selected film was *Lost in Translation* (2003, Drama/Comedy) which was shot completely in Japan. Discussions with viewers that have seen the film as well as a comparison with other Japan-filmed movies contributed to the final selection of the film. Message boards on the film's website and film review websites were also observed. The film has been critically acclaimed and has received numerous awards. This film could be placed in the category of Tourism Poster Film, according to a typology of films created by Mestre et al. (2008). According to the description of the category, in this type of film the main argumentative line is traveling acts that viewers can find the common elements of a tourist trip—such as accommodations, restaurants and cuisine, local architecture, shopping, and so on. Also, these types of films have a foreign traveler who discovers a new culture, city, or country when he arrives at his goal destination. *Lost in Translation* (2003) is about two different Americans situated in Tokyo. The two characters venture through Tokyo having interesting experiences with the local residents along the way. The film portrays the modern and traditional architecture, nightlife entertainment, and beautiful countryside of the nation but an important piece of the film is about cultural differences. The upscale Park Hyatt Hotel was a character itself with almost every aspect of the hotel shown in the film. It has been reported that many people were attracted to the hotel as a

result of the filming of this movie on its premises (Gibson, 2004).

### **Sampling Frame and Data Collection**

The data collection method chosen for this study was a one-group pretest-posttest quasi-experimental design. This type of pre-experimental design has a single pretest observation taken on a group of respondents, and then treatment occurs. This is followed by a single posttest observation on the same measures (Shadish, Cook, & Campbell, 2002). The vast majority of studies used this type of research design; however, researchers have identified several threats to validity of the design, such as history, maturation, and spontaneous changes (Shadish et al., 2002). The data were collected in a classroom setting and each session was performed on the same day to the same group of participants within an hour to minimize those biases that might influence the results. It is argued that social scientists in field settings will be able to construct confident causal knowledge with the simple pretest-posttest design when the outcomes are particularly well-behaved and the interval between pretest and posttest is short (Shadish et al., 2002). This research design was chosen because of concern about data contamination and memory decay if other methods based on memory without any stimuli were used since there are a variety of information sources that might influence individuals' image of a destination.

The sample comprised of 247 undergraduate students registered at a southeastern university in the United States. There were eight classes—different sections of the same course—that participated in the study. The classes were selected based on the large enrollment and the mix of time the classes were held. Each experiment was conducted during each regular scheduled class time for the participating classes and participation of students was voluntary. The identity of respondents and all responses were kept confidential using a numerical coding system. The screening time was reduced to 50 minutes of selected chapters from the movie instead of the full length (1 hour 42 minutes) due to time constraints. This process of editing

was done in order to fit the movie within the time frame in which the classes were offered and to allow for sufficient time for explaining the process to the participants and completing the pretest and posttest. Scenes that were eliminated were those that were repetitive, had too much dialog, and were not relevant to the study.

### **Data Analysis**

Data were entered into and analyzed with Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) version 16.0 for Windows. Paired samples *t*-test was used to find out statistically significant differences between the pretest and posttest mean scores of the 16 destination image attributes. For further analysis, factor analysis was used on the 16 attributes to discover underlying dimensions to summarize the variables in a smaller set of factors and to identify the structural difference between the pretest and posttest. Finally, on the basis of the factor analysis, path analysis was conducted to examine the strength of the effect of destination image attributes and overall image on travel intentions.

## **STUDY RESULTS**

The first question of the pretest questionnaire was a culling question that asked if respondents had visited China, France, Italy, and/or Japan. The purpose of this question was to eliminate those respondents that had already been to Japan from the data analysis. Previous visitors to a destination are likely to have more realistic, complex, and positive image than non-visitors (Chon, 1990, 1991; Pearce, 1982; Tiefenbacher, Day, & Walton, 2000). The results showed that only three respondents had been to Japan in the past five years. These respondents were excluded from further analysis. In regards to international travel experience of the respondents, only 22% had taken one international trip and 23.6% had taken two or more in the past 3 years. More than half of the respondents had been to a movie theater six times or more during the past 6 months. The majority of the respondents (83.6%) had not seen the movie prior to

the experiment. The profile of respondents were found to be mostly female (65.9%), white, non-Hispanic (74.4%), and age 25 or under (96.7%). The nature of the sample was homogeneous but matched the demographic profile of the student population in this study.

This study used 16 destination image attributes in order to measure the image of the destination, Japan. First, paired samples *t*-test was employed to see the statistical significant differences between the pretest and posttest. The results of this test showed that eight attributes had a statistically significant mean difference—mostly positive—before and after the film (Table 1). The attribute that showed the largest increase in mean score was “quality accommodations” (mean difference = 0.64,  $p < .001$ ). This increase in mean score could be attributed to the upscale hotel being a major part of the film. The open-ended responses related to hotel/accommodation were among the most popular responses contributing to the positive image of Japan as a tourist destination. The second largest mean score increase was “friendly/hospitable people” (mean difference = 0.63,  $p < .001$ ). The largest decrease in mean score was “no difficulty communicating in English” (mean difference = -0.25,  $p < .001$ ). This decrease could be influenced by the respondents seeing how the characters were having challenges in communicating with the local people in the film. This is also evidenced by the language barrier being the most popular open-ended response for having a negative image of Japan as a tourist destination. More interestingly, the decreased standard deviations indicate less dispersion among the respondents after viewing the film. Therefore, watching the film increased the agreement among respondents implying an impact of the film on perceptions of certain image attributes.

In addition to the structured image attribute questions, open-ended responses captured the unique and distinctive images that supported the influence of the film on respondents' perceptions of Japan. The changes were more specific to the content of the film. As an example, the largest increase in the number of written words or phrases was related to the urbanized aspect of the country. It was the top ranked

TABLE 1. Paired Samples T-Test on 16 Destination Image Attributes

| Destination image attribute            | Pretest Mean (SD) | Posttest Mean (SD) | $\Delta$ Mean ( $\Delta$ SD) | t-value | df  | Sig. (2-tailed) |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|------------------------------|---------|-----|-----------------|
| <b>Positive mean difference</b>        |                   |                    |                              |         |     |                 |
| Cleanliness/hygiene                    | 3.55 (1.05)       | 4.00 (1.02)        | 0.45 (−0.03)                 | −6.363  | 243 | .000**          |
| Restful/relaxing                       | 3.17 (0.99)       | 3.21 (1.22)        | 0.04 (0.23)                  | −0.548  | 243 | .584            |
| Friendly/hospitable people             | 3.50 (0.92)       | 4.13 (0.95)        | 0.63 (0.03)                  | −9.237  | 243 | .000**          |
| Safe place to visit                    | 3.50 (0.88)       | 3.68 (1.09)        | 0.18 (0.21)                  | −2.283  | 243 | .023*           |
| Quality accommodations                 | 3.65 (0.92)       | 4.29 (0.91)        | 0.64 (−0.01)                 | −9.541  | 243 | .000**          |
| Quality shopping facilities            | 3.78 (1.07)       | 3.92 (0.99)        | 0.14 (−0.08)                 | −1.806  | 243 | .072            |
| Reliable local transportation          | 3.40 (0.92)       | 3.88 (1.04)        | 0.48 (0.12)                  | −6.731  | 243 | .000**          |
| Quality nightlife entertainment        | 3.63 (0.91)       | 4.18 (0.97)        | 0.55 (0.06)                  | −7.690  | 243 | .000**          |
| Natural scenic beauty                  | 4.12 (0.95)       | 4.17 (1.00)        | 0.05 (0.05)                  | −0.808  | 243 | .420            |
| Cultural sites of interest             | 4.04 (1.01)       | 4.09 (0.95)        | 0.05 (−0.06)                 | −0.667  | 243 | .505            |
| Beautiful architecture                 | 4.09 (0.94)       | 4.22 (1.03)        | 0.13 (0.09)                  | −1.865  | 243 | .063            |
| Good value for the money               | 3.43 (1.05)       | 3.44 (1.12)        | 0.01 (0.07)                  | −0.204  | 243 | .839            |
| <b>Negative mean difference</b>        |                   |                    |                              |         |     |                 |
| Appealing local food                   | 3.78 (1.18)       | 3.63 (1.30)        | −0.15 (0.12)                 | 2.189   | 243 | .030*           |
| No difficulty communicating in English | 2.57 (1.07)       | 2.32 (1.15)        | −0.25 (0.08)                 | 2.728   | 243 | .007**          |
| Interesting customs                    | 4.08 (0.93)       | 4.05 (1.04)        | −0.03 (0.11)                 | 0.554   | 243 | .580            |
| Variety of historic sites              | 4.03 (0.98)       | 3.98 (1.05)        | −0.05 (0.07)                 | 0.678   | 243 | .499            |

Note. Pretest and posttest mean value 1 = *strongly disagree* and 5 = *strongly agree*.

\* $p < .05$ , \*\* $p < .01$ .

category on the posttest compared to fourth on the pretest. The film's depiction of the city life of Tokyo from the high-rise hotel and buildings to the bright neon lights at night contributed to that leaving a strong impression in the participants' minds. Another large percentage change—in this case a decrease—from the pretest to the posttest was found on the historical and cultural aspects. The historical and cultural images that respondents have already possessed could have been simply reinforced rather than newly created and the unexpected more modernized and urbanized aspects of the country could have become a stronger image and more appealing to this younger generation group. The overall difference of the open-ended responses between the pretest and the posttest is that the majority of responses were related to natural amenities—such as the cuisine, historical and cultural aspects, and scenery on the pretest—whereas the majority of responses on the posttest were related to the urbanized and modernized aspect of Japan including

crowded/busy, nightlife/entertainment, and technology.

Factor analysis was applied on the 16 destination image attributes, primarily to find a structural difference between the pretest and posttest. Varimax rotation method was used as it provides a clearer separation of the factors and improves the interpretation by reducing some of the ambiguities that often accompany unrotated factor solutions (Hair, Black, Babin, Anderson, & Tatham, 2006). Internal reliability of each of the factors was done by calculating Cronbach's alpha. All of the factors had Cronbach's alpha exceeding .70 indicating consistency of the measurement. Factor loadings .50 or greater are considered practically significant (Hair et al., 2006). Therefore, items with factor loadings less than .50 that reduced the reliability were eliminated from further analysis (three items from the pretest and four from the posttest). The remaining variables were very well-defined and represented three distinct groups of variables for the pretest and

two for the posttest. The three factors for the pretest with eigenvalues greater than 1 explained 61.51% of the variance of the destination image scale. For the posttest, only two factors with eigenvalues greater than one were extracted and 59.83% of the variance was explained. In addition to the decreased standard deviations in Table 1, the structural difference between the pretest and posttest is another evidence

of respondents' diverse perceptions becoming more homogeneous. More specifically, the number of factors from the pretest to the posttest has been reduced (from three to two). On the posttest, two factors ("tourism infrastructure" and "atmosphere") that were separate on the pretest became a single factor ("tourism atmosphere and infrastructure"). The results of the factor analysis are presented in Tables 2 and 3.

TABLE 2. Factor Loadings and Reliability Tests of the Destination Image Attributes—Pretest

| Factors                             | Factor loading | Eigenvalue | % of variance | Cumulative % of variance | Cronbach's alpha |
|-------------------------------------|----------------|------------|---------------|--------------------------|------------------|
| Natural amenities                   |                | 7.31       | 45.66         | 45.66                    | 0.93             |
| Variety of historic sites           | 0.87           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Beautiful architecture              | 0.82           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Natural scenic beauty               | 0.82           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Cultural sites of interest          | 0.81           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Interesting customs                 | 0.75           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Tourism infrastructure              |                | 1.44       | 9.00          | 54.66                    | 0.83             |
| Quality shopping centers/facilities | 0.78           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Quality accommodations              | 0.74           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Quality nightlife entertainment     | 0.67           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Reliable local transportation       | 0.66           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Atmosphere                          |                | 1.10       | 6.85          | 61.51                    | 0.77             |
| Friendly and hospitable people      | 0.72           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Restful and relaxing place          | 0.70           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Safe place to visit                 | 0.68           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Cleanliness and hygiene             | 0.67           |            |               |                          |                  |

TABLE 3. Factor Loadings and Reliability Tests of the Destination Image Attributes—Posttest

| Factors                               | Factor loading | Eigenvalue | % of variance | Cumulative % of variance | Cronbach's alpha |
|---------------------------------------|----------------|------------|---------------|--------------------------|------------------|
| Natural amenities                     |                | 8.33       | 52.04         | 52.04                    | 0.92             |
| Cultural sites of interest            | 0.87           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Natural scenic beauty                 | 0.82           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Variety of historic sites             | 0.81           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Beautiful architecture                | 0.77           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Interesting customs                   | 0.73           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Quality accommodations                | 0.69           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Tourism atmosphere and infrastructure |                | 1.25       | 7.79          | 59.83                    | 0.86             |
| Safe place to visit                   | 0.74           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Restful and relaxing place            | 0.70           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Reliable local transportation         | 0.70           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Friendly and hospitable people        | 0.69           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Quality shopping centers/facilities   | 0.62           |            |               |                          |                  |
| Cleanliness and hygiene               | 0.54           |            |               |                          |                  |

Lastly, the above factor analysis reduced the number of variables in a smaller set for a more parsimonious path analysis. The path model was tested to empirically analyze the strength of the relationships among destination image attributes, overall image, level of interest in visiting the destination, and the likelihood to visit the destination in 12 months. The independent variables representing specific destination images are the factors extracted from the previous factor analysis results. For the pretest, “natural amenities,” “tourism infrastructure,” and “atmosphere” were the three measurement variables of destination image (independent variables), while for the posttest, “natural amenities” and “tourism atmosphere and infrastructure” were the two variables used. For both the pretest and posttest, “overall image” served as the mediating variable. There was a single item used to evaluate the overall image of the destination: “In general, what image do you have of Japan as a tourist destination?” which was measured on a 5-point Likert scale (5 = *extremely positive*, 1 = *extremely negative*). Two items were used to measure travel intentions. The two dependent variables were “visit interest in future” and “likely to visit in 12 months.” The “visit interest in future” question was the first of the two that was measured on a 5-point Likert scale (5 = *extremely interested*, 1 = *not at all interested*): “What is your level of interest in visiting Japan sometime in the future” for each pretest and posttest. The second question regarding “likely to visit in 12 months” was also measured on a 5-point Likert scale (5 = *very likely*, 1 = *not at all likely*): “How likely is that you will travel to Japan for vacation in the next 12 months” for each pretest and posttest. This question is more goal specific than the other one. In addition, if the respondent answered “not at all likely” or “not very likely,” there was a follow-up question that asked for the reason. There were nine possible answers where the last one was an open-ended response to specify the reason. Respondents were asked to circle all that applied.

The goodness-of-fit of the path model was assessed. The path model for the pretest shows that  $\chi^2$  is 10.57 ( $df = 6$ ) and the  $\chi^2/df$  ratio is 1.76. The ratio of  $\chi^2/df$  has been recommended

as a better goodness of fit than  $\chi^2$  because  $\chi^2$  value is very sensitive to sample size which many times result in rejecting the model (Hair et al., 2006). Also, a level of the  $\chi^2/df$  ratio below 3 is good (Chen & Tsai, 2007), meaning this model fits the data well. For the posttest model,  $\chi^2$  is 10.94 ( $df = 4$ ) and  $\chi^2/df$  ratio is 2.74. The indicators suggest that the posttest model is also a good fit for the data. Other statistics have also been applied to assess the model fitness. The fit indices for the pretest and posttest are presented in Table 4.

The indirect effects of the independent variables (destination attributes) on the dependent variables (travel intentions) for both the pretest and posttest are also calculated. The path analysis showed that destination image attributes have a positive direct effect on overall image of the destination for both pretest ( $\gamma = .19, p < .01$ ,  $\gamma = .14, p < .10$ , and  $\gamma = .30, p < .01$ ) and posttest ( $\gamma = .16, p < .05$  and  $\gamma = .18, p < .01$ ). The destination image attributes have an indirect effect on level of interest in visiting the destination for both pretest ( $\gamma = .09, \gamma = .07$ , and  $\gamma = .15$ ) and posttest ( $\gamma = .12$  and  $\gamma = .13$ ) which are statistically significant at either .05 or .10 level. Overall image has a positive direct effect on level of interest in visiting the destination in the future for both pretest ( $\beta = .49, p < .01$ ) and posttest ( $\beta = .72, p < .01$ ). However, overall image has a positive direct effect on likelihood

TABLE 4. Fit Indices and Determination Coefficients

| Fit statistics               | Pretest model | Posttest model |
|------------------------------|---------------|----------------|
| df                           | 6             | 4              |
| $\chi^2$                     | 10.57 (.103)  | 10.94 (.027)   |
| $\chi^2/df$                  | 1.76          | 2.74           |
| GFI                          | .986          | .982           |
| AGFI                         | .949          | .932           |
| NFI                          | .920          | .927           |
| CFI                          | .961          | .951           |
| RMR                          | .049          | .045           |
| RMSEA                        | .056          | .085           |
| % of variance explained      |               |                |
| Overall image                | .39           | .39            |
| Visit interest in future     | .59           | .58            |
| Likely to visit in 12 months | .58           | .59            |

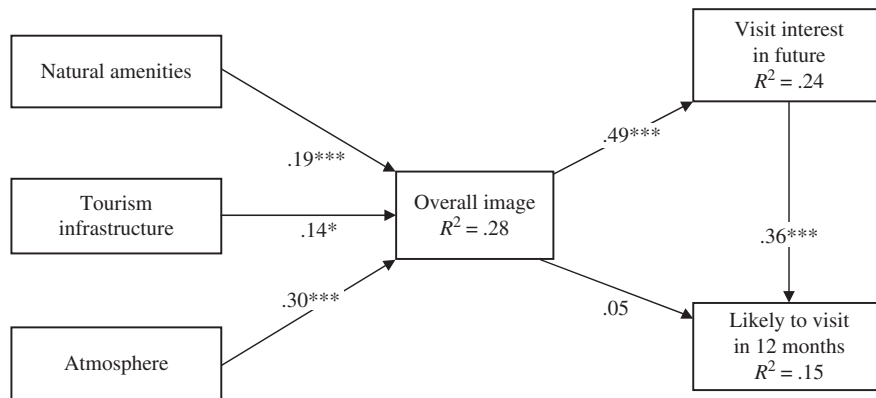
to visit the destination in 12 months only for the posttest ( $\beta = .30, p < .01$ ). Finally, level of interest in visiting the destination has a positive direct effect on likelihood to visit the destination in 12 months for both pretest ( $\beta = .36, p < .01$ ) and posttest ( $\beta = .34, p < .01$ ). The results of the path analysis are illustrated in Figures 1 (pretest) and 2 (posttest), respectively.

For the pretest, the  $R^2$  of overall image was 0.28, indicating that 28% of the variance in overall image can be attributed to the destination attributes. "Atmosphere" had the strongest direct effect on overall image followed by "natural amenities" and "tourism infrastructure." The  $R^2$  for visit interest in future was 0.24, indicating 24% of the variance being explained by

the overall image. The  $R^2$  for likely to visit in 12 months was 0.15, indicating that 15% of the variance can be attributed to the visit interest in future.

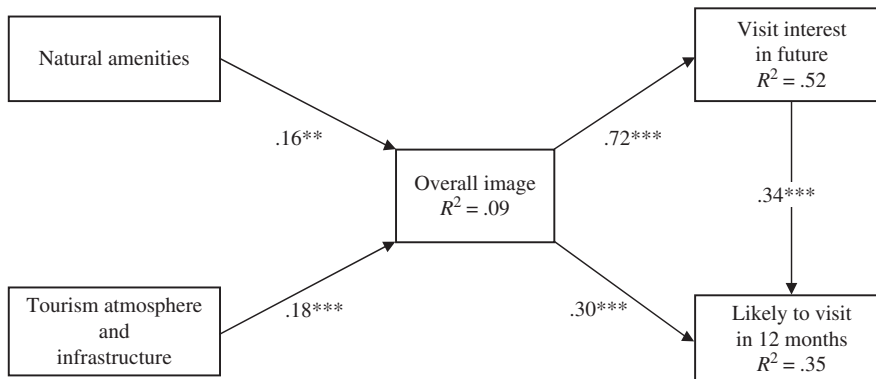
For the posttest, the  $R^2$  of overall image was 0.09, indicating that only 9% of the variance in overall image can be explained by the destination attributes. "Tourism atmosphere and infrastructure" had a stronger direct effect on overall image than "natural amenities." The  $R^2$  of visit interest in future was 0.52, indicating that 52% of the variance can be attributed to overall image. The  $R^2$  of likely to visit in 12 months was 0.35, indicating that 35% of the variance can be explained by visit interest in future.

FIGURE 1. Path Model of Image and Travel Intentions—Pretest



Note. \* $p < .10$ , \*\* $p < .05$ , \*\*\* $p < .01$ .

FIGURE 2. Path Model of Image and Travel Intentions—Posttest



Note. \* $p < .10$ , \*\* $p < .05$ , \*\*\* $p < .01$ .

For both the pretest and posttest, the strongest direct effect was found by overall image on visit interest in future ( $\beta = .49$  and  $\beta = .72$ ). The direct effect of overall image on likely to visit in 12 months increased from pretest ( $\beta = .05$ ) to posttest ( $\beta = .30$ ), indicating that after the film, the likelihood to visit in 12 months increased. This is also evidenced by the increase in  $R^2$  from pretest (0.15) to posttest (0.35). In both cases, the direct effect of visit interest in future is stronger than overall image on likely to visit in 12 months.

In both pretest and posttest, overall image did not play a significant role as a mediating variable. The  $R^2$  decrease from pretest (0.28) to posttest (0.09) indicates that the role of overall image as a mediating variable becomes even less after the viewing of the film. This means that respondents relied more on specific destination attributes in making their decision on travel intentions which is more prominent after the film. More detailed images have been formed and respondents tend to rely more on the specific image attributes rather than the overall image. Moreover, different factors have a more powerful effect than the overall image as a mediating variable on a person's intention to visit.

For both the pretest and posttest, the indirect paths of destination image attributes with overall image as a mediating variable were stronger toward the level of interest in visiting the destination than the more goal specific likelihood to visit the destination in 12 months. This result could be attributed to the fact that planning to visit a destination cannot be decided in a short period of time, especially when the destination is culturally and physically distant. This was supported by the follow-up question where the majority of respondents selected time and travel cost, followed by language barrier and distance as travel constraints on visiting Japan in the next 12 months.

## CONCLUSIONS AND IMPLICATIONS

The objectives of this study were to assess the impact of a specific film on the featured destination's image and to examine the

effect of destination image attributes and overall image on travel intentions. The findings of this study showed that the film had statistically significant impacts—both positive and negative—on respondents' perceived image of Japan as a tourist destination. This result agrees with Hudson and Ritchie (2006) in that the positive and negative impacts have an effect on certain destination attributes and that film-specific factors have an influence on destination attributes. In the film, the upscale hotel was portrayed almost as a main character which could have impacted the "quality accommodations" attribute in a more positive light hence showing the most positive impact on the mean score. Similarly, but in an opposite direction, the film portrayed the two American characters having a hard time communicating with the locals which could have led to the most decrease in mean score on the "no difficulty in communicating in English" attribute. At the minimum, these two examples demonstrate the fact that film-specific factors had a direct influence on the related destination attributes. The perceived image of the destination attributes became more detailed yet limited to what has been shown in the film.

The structural difference between the pretest (three factors) and the posttest (two factors) as a result of the factor analysis provided evidence that the responses became more homogeneous and focused after the film. In addition, the factor that showed more influence on the overall image of the destination on the posttest—"tourism atmosphere and infrastructure"—consisted of more specific attributes, such as "reliable local transportation" and "quality shopping centers/facilities" compared to the pretest's "atmosphere" factor. This finding again demonstrates that the film directly influences detailed images of the destination.

Moreover, the path analysis results illustrated that the role of the overall image as a mediating variable is minimized as respondents might have relied more on specific image attributes directly captured from the film in their travel intentions. This is another indication that respondents' image of the destination became more detailed after viewing the film. Moreover, the indirect paths to travel intentions showed that the path toward the level of interest in visiting

Japan sometime in the future was stronger than the path toward the goal specific likelihood of visiting Japan in 12 months. This result supports other researchers in that the film could strengthen an already existing interest rather than directly impacting the decision to travel to the destination (Iwashita, 2003; Macionis & Sparks, 2009). Lastly, the overall image had a positive effect on likelihood to visit the destination in 12 months only for the posttest. This finding suggests that the viewing of the film created a stronger intention to visit the destination in the near future.

Film-induced tourism offers tremendous opportunities for tourism organizations, particularly DMOs (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). The findings of this particular study imply that it is possible to make a general connection between the pre and post viewings of a film. Therefore, this article supports existing studies by providing marketing implications for destinations in their efforts to manage their images portrayed in a film. DMOs can use these commercial films as springboards for marketing campaigns and generate marketing opportunities at the different stages of the production process.

First, although DMOs do not usually have complete control over how a location was depicted in a film, it is important for destination marketers to take the exposure as an opportunity to create or remodel their image management strategy depending on how the destination was portrayed. At a minimum level, marketers should be aware of the content of the film and identify how the destination was depicted in it. This is extremely important seeing that the portrayal of a destination in a film affects viewers' image of the location and travel intentions to it which was evidenced in this study. The path toward the level of interest in visiting the destination sometime in the future was stronger than the likelihood to visit in 12 months. This result indicates that the film increased awareness that could lead to searching for more information regarding the destination and further being considered as a potential travel destination. This level of awareness can prepare destination marketers to adjust or create their communication and marketing strategies in order to make the film work to the destination's advantage (Croy

& Walker, 2003). Second, as seen in some of the examples mentioned in this study, DMOs can be more proactive in promoting their destinations to film production in order to increase awareness of the destination (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006) that could possibly lead to actual visits. It has now become a very competitive market to attract film producers to base their productions in specific locations (Croy, 2010), as evidenced with some DMO websites in the United States (e.g., Austin, Texas and Miami, Florida) welcoming film production by providing the necessary resources on the websites. Hudson and Ritchie (2006) showed that DMOs can be involved in location scouting at the preproduction stage to make sure the film depicts scenes to the destination's advantage. During the production of the film, publicity can be maximized by working with the producer's publicist throughout the film production process to make sure a consistent message and right image is conveyed about the location. After the release of the film, efforts by the DMO could help potential visitors to make the connection between the film and the destination, especially utilizing the websites. Tourism New Zealand notably placed major films, their film locations, and experiences on their website following the success of *The Lord of the Rings* (Croy, 2010). Media attention can be attracted to the film location and promote it as a tourist attraction. In addition, guidebooks, postcards, documentaries, and tours to filmed sites can maximize exposure, increase awareness, and strengthen the attractiveness of the destination (Hudson & Ritchie, 2006). When designing a promotional campaign using films, DMOs should keep in mind that the traditional advertising format should be avoided for a favorable image as framed promotional contents of a destination could sometimes have a negative effect on the viewers (Mestre et al., 2008).

DMOs should recognize the power of film on creating awareness, enhancing existing images, changing images, and igniting a motivation to visit a place. Most importantly, DMOs need to understand that building a positive image or changing a negative one is a long process (Gartner & Shen, 1992). Therefore, an ongoing strategic image management process should

be in place and constantly monitored (Barich & Kotler, 1991). As suggested by Croy (2010), this process should become inherent in destination management with an emphasis that image management is more than simply promoting images. DMOs should consider films as an opportunity to generate more awareness of the destination before expecting a huge increase on the number of visitors.

### **LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH**

There are some limitations in this study that could be addressed in future research. First, the impact of destination image and the structural relationships between variables were tested utilizing data collected from a convenience sample. The results of this study are more representative of the study population which is college students. Study results of a different population could be compared to the current study. Second, the initial interest or willingness to view the film could affect the emotional involvement or experience with the film and further influence their image and travel intentions to the destination. Thus, studying viewers' emotional involvement or experience during the film could bring interesting results. Viewers often make a connection with the characters and associate themselves with them that could influence their decision of a destination. Third, the study adopted the one-group pretest-posttest quasi-experimental design. In order to improve the internal and external validity of the study, future research should use a true experimental design which includes a control group, such as the pretest-posttest control group design or the Solomon four-group design (Shadish et al., 2002). Fourth, this study only examined travel intentions to a certain extent, not the actual travel behavior. There are many aspects that are involved in planning to visit a destination that cannot be decided in a short period of time. How much of the film translates into actual visitation is not presented in this study nor is the extent of the film playing a role in the initial image formation stage before the trip as it is the most important phase in the destination

selection process (Gunn, 1988; Mercer, 1971). Lastly, it would be interesting to explore impacts of different film genres rather than using one type of film. Various types of film could impact viewers' interest and image of a destination and/or travel intentions. Also, films with a positive outlook on a destination or a negative portrayal would yield different travel intentions. Therefore, it would be interesting to explore different genres or types of films. Despite the limitations, this study provided sound results of the impact of film on destination image and travel intentions to the film location with implications for destination marketers.

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